

Gorilla gorilla

Western gorilla



Height 3¼–3½ ft (1–1.1 m)

Tail None

Weight 125–430 lb (57–195 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Critically endangered



The largest living primates, gorillas are day-active forest dwellers that feed on fruit, leaves, stems, and seeds, as well as a few small creatures such as termites. At night, they bend tree twigs and branches to form a sleeping nest. Living in small,

stable groups of 3–20 with strong bonds between the silverback (dominant male) and the females with offspring, the western gorilla uses a wide range of facial expressions, body gestures, and sounds to communicate, including whimpers, grunts, rumbles of contentment, and alarm barks. Its home range of 2,000–4,450 acres (800–1,800 hectares) may overlap with neighboring groups but is not actively defended. The single young is born after a gestation of 257 days. It clings to its mother's belly for 4–6 months, then rides on her shoulders or back. It first chews vegetation at 4 months and is weaned by 3 years. They mature at 4–5 years.

SILVERBACK
The adult male gorilla is almost twice the weight of the female, and has a taller bony head crest, longer canine teeth, and a "saddle" of silvery fur.

NERVOUS BEHAVIOR



When nervous, gorillas may "yawn" (above). They usually avoid danger by walking quietly in single file into thick forest—termed "silent flight." In active defense, the silverback barks and stares. If the threat persists, he may charge (see panel, below).

CONSERVATION

The main threats to western gorillas are slash-and-burn clearance of their forest habitat, illegal hunting for the commercial bushmeat trade, and trophy poaching. Almost all gorillas in zoos and parks belong to this species, but reintroductions of captive-bred individuals into the wild are rarely attempted, partly due to the gorilla's complex, close-knit social life. Habitat conservation remains the long-term priority.



Gorilla beringei

Eastern gorilla



Height 3¼–4 ft (1–1.2 m)

Tail None

Weight 150–460 lb (68–210 kg)

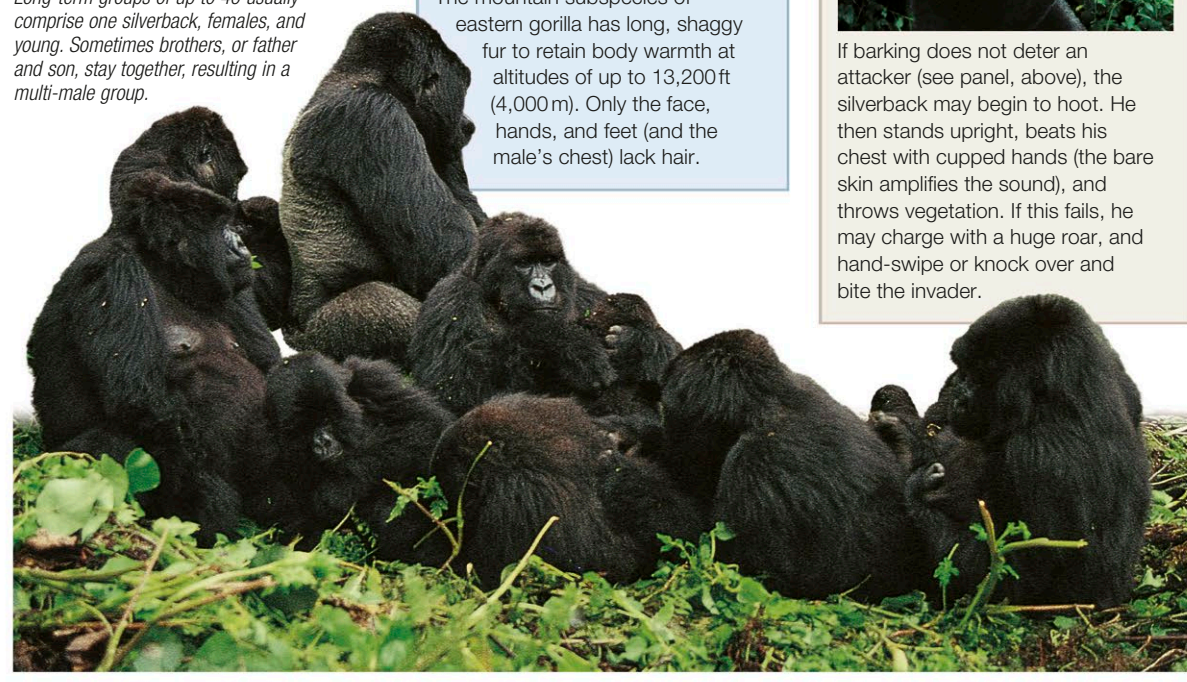
Social unit Group

Status Critically endangered

Previously considered a subspecies of the western gorilla, this species includes eastern lowland gorillas (*Gorilla beringei graueri*), and one or more subspecies of mountain gorillas (such as *Gorilla beringei beringei*). Each group roams a home range of 1,000–2,000 acres (400–800 hectares), which, apart from a central core area, may overlap with neighboring groups. Main foods are leaves, shoots, and stems, especially bamboo; also fruit, roots, soft bark, and fungi. Occasionally, ants are scooped up and swallowed quickly before they bite. At dusk, the group settles to rest—the adult males on the ground, females and young sometimes in nests in trees. Each female shares a nest with her current offspring. The dominant silverback fathers most or all young in the group. He gains the attention of receptive females with mock feeding, hoots, chest-beating, thumping plants, or jump-kicking. A female who has bred,

is unlikely to transfer to another male unless her original mate is killed. The offspring remains with its mother until her next birth, after about 4 years. Some eastern gorillas attract tourist income and receive protection, but others are at continued risk from poaching.

GORILLA GROUP
Long-term groups of up to 40 usually comprise one silverback, females, and young. Sometimes brothers, or father and son, stay together, resulting in a multi-male group.

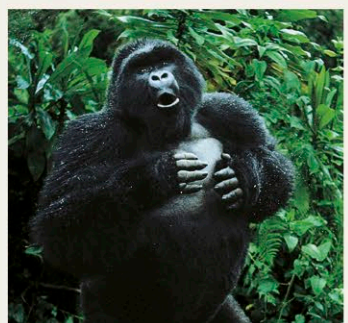


WARM FUR



The mountain subspecies of eastern gorilla has long, shaggy fur to retain body warmth at altitudes of up to 13,200 ft (4,000 m). Only the face, hands, and feet (and the male's chest) lack hair.

DEFENSE DISPLAY



If barking does not deter an attacker (see panel, above), the silverback may begin to hoot. He then stands upright, beats his chest with cupped hands (the bare skin amplifies the sound), and throws vegetation. If this fails, he may charge with a huge roar, and hand-swipe or knock over and bite the invader.